

When They Ask About a Failure

A credible answer owns the decision, names the learning and avoids rewriting the past.

THE DECISION

Strong failure stories are neither confessionals nor disguised victories. They show how you noticed a problem, what responsibility you took, what changed in your approach and how that learning now informs your judgment.

THREE MOVES

- Choose an example with a real trade-off, a miss or a decision you would now handle differently.
- Be precise about your role; do not hide behind “we” when the interviewer needs to understand your judgment.
- Describe the change you made afterward and the evidence that it became part of your operating practice.

TRY THIS BEFORE YOUR NEXT STEP

Write one sentence for each: what happened, what you owned, what you learned, and what you now do differently. Remove any sentence that blames another person.

Reading note: This is a sample briefing for educational reading. It is not a historic newsletter send and does not guarantee an interview, offer or outcome. Framework reference: [MIT Career Advising & Professional Development — STAR method](#).